Ass Burger

By Augusten Burroughs

INTRODUCTION

People with Asperger's Syndrome are often described as having social skills deficits, a reluctance to listen, difficulty understanding social give and take, and other core characteristics. So let's see . . . based on these "symptoms" – Abraham Lincoln, Albert Einstein, Emily Dickinson and Beethoven would have been suffering from this syndrome. Why is it that people who function outside what society has determined is "normal" must have a diagnosis, a mental disorder . . . a syndrome? Can't people just be appreciated for the unique individuals they are?

In Ass Burger by Augusten Burroughs, acceptance is a given, the diagnosis is merely "secondary information."

NARRATOR: **(Pg 171 – 180)** The summer my big brother, John, turned fifteen, he read the Encyclopedia Britannica from A to Z. As he finished each volume, he would leave it on my bed, so that I could do likewise. But I did **not** do likewise. What little factual information I absorbed in my life was gleaned from lectures the Professor gave to Gilligan. . . He simply could not comprehend this.

4NG Fanatics

JOHN: You didn't read any of them?

NARRATOR: I looked at some of the pictures . . . Those transparent pages with naked people and their insides, that was neat.

JOHN: Well, that's just unacceptable. I mean, you're reading at a third-grade level. Don't you find that alarming?

NARRATOR: Considering I was in the third grade, no, I didn't. And from this moment on my brother treated me as not just his younger brother, but his "borderline retarded" younger brother. In fact, this is exactly how he introduced me to his friends:

JOHN: This is my younger brother. You can just ignore him; he's basically retarded. Our mother smoked while she was pregnant with him, and I guess there was brain damage.

NARRATOR: But to me, it was my brother who seemed retarded. Either that or a genius, I couldn't decide. All I knew for sure was that he was a peculiar creature. While he could not fathom a younger brother who did not share his fascination with quantum mechanics, I

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

likewise could not comprehend that my brother didn't own a single pair of platform shoes. As far as I was concerned, he was in training to become a creepy gas station attendant, while I was going to be a star. . . So what, exactly, was he? On the one hand, my brother knew how to create something called a circuit board, which, when attached with wires to a series of strobe lights and placed next to our sleeping mother, provided a shocking amount of fun. Instead of a baseball glove, my brother had an oscilloscope on his dresser. And if you asked him, "Are platinum records really made of platinum?" you would get a thirty-minute discourse on the periodic table, including the half-life of each element.

But on the other hand, my brother seemed like somebody best confined to a basement. Not only was he gruff and abrupt, but he spoke in a deadly monotone at all times. He never made eye contact. And he took no pride in his appearance, seeing nothing wrong with wearing pants that had been too short for years. When my parents had guests, my brother often asked shockingly rude questions:

4NG Fanatics

JOHN: Didn't you have an abortion last year?

MOM: *(shrieking)* John, that is absolutely none of your business. How dare you ask such a question!

JOHN: *(grunting, then snorting)* Well, I thought you said she had an abortion. One of your friends did. I thought it was this 'Nancy' character.

NARRATOR: Thankfully, my brother spent much of his time alone in his room, the walls of which were covered with images of trains: steam engines, cabooses, sometimes close-ups of the wheels themselves. Quite different from the walls of my room, which were decorated with pages torn from Tiger Beat.

Occasionally, we would do "activities" together. Once, we took an old pair of his jeans and an old shirt and stuffed them with bed sheets. Next we stapled the seams to create a "body." My brother then led me down a path a few miles from our house, and we tied a rope around the body and slung it up over one of the rails of the power-line scaffolding. Later at home my brother phoned the local police and informed them that there had been a ritual hanging in the neighborhood. As

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

sirens streamed down our little dirt road my brother smirked and chuckled.

JOHN: That should occupy them for a while.

NARRATOR: My brother moved out of the house when he was seventeen and began living with a rock band. He wasn't interested in playing an instrument; he was interested in building the various electronic components. Word spread about a grubby, clever kid who was good with electronics. And this is how it happened that my strange and aloof brother built the rocket-shooting, fire-spitting, exploding guitars for the band Kiss. His name began to appear in magazines next to the word "brilliant."

Other kids say "My big brother can beat you up." I was able to say "My big brother is a genius like Einstein."

It's twenty-five years later, and my brother's rock-band days are over. He owns a very successful car dealership and service center where he sells previously owned Range Rovers, Rolls Royces, and other staggeringly expensive cars. He is married now, and he has a son. We speak on the phone each day because he calls me on the way to work in the morning.

4N6 Fanatics

My brother never asks how I am or what I'm feeling. He simply begins speaking, as though we have already been on the phone for an hour. Often, he begins mid-thought.

JOHN: So the kid, he's not very happy with me - I told him about Santa Claus. . . . I said, 'You know kid, Santa can't earn a living working just one day a year.' And then I told him how on the off-season, Santa works at Europort in Rotterdam, unloading container ships. Only he got fired for drinking on the job, and now he's depressed, so there might not even be a Christmas this year. *(laughs)*

NARRATOR: I smile at how awful he is to his ten-year-old son, who already takes his father with a grain of salt. (to John) That's horrible. You shouldn't tell him things like that.

JOHN: *(laughing)* Oh, and I went to a psychologist, and she said I have Asperger's syndrome.

NARRATOR: What?

JOHN: She said I've had it my whole life, and it explains why people think I'm weird.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

NARRATOR: Wait a minute, what? Why did you see a psychologist? What is this thing called again? *(to audience)* He tells me the name again and spells it (because I thought it was "Ass-Burger") and then says, "I gotta run." And he is gone. I go online to read about this condition, which my brother suddenly has, which sounds like a sandwich made from donkey flesh.

Asperger's syndrome was named for Hans Asperger, a Viennese physician who published a paper in 1944 describing autistic-like behavior in several young boys. But it wasn't until 1994 that Asperger's syndrome was added to the DSM IV, and only in the past few years has AS been recognized by professionals and parents. So for fifty years, these kids were driving their families insane, undiagnosed, and wanting to chase trains in the car.

And now, suddenly, Asperger's syndrome is chic.

Bill Gates is said to have Asperger's. It is also suspected that the condition afflicted Albert Einstein. It is associated with geniuses, and this is why Manhattan parents are often secretly thrilled to have their bratty, brainy, introverted children diagnosed with this

4NG Fanatics

condition. It is the first trendy thing ever to occur in the atmosphere surrounding my brother.

People with Asperger's tend to be obsessed with trains and cars. My brother's first word was "car." He owns a car dealership that fixes high-end automobiles. And all his life his walls (and now office) have been hung with pictures of trains. Check.

People with Asperger's tend to have "fanciful vocabularies." Immediately, I know exactly what this means. When my brother's dog is happy, he describes it as "tail up."

JOHN: Yup. Dog-o is tail up ninety percent of the time.

NARRATOR: He also speaks of Fire Lizards. These, he claims, are employed in shops by glass artisans. They sleep on the floor in the work area, and then the glass blower steps on the Fire Lizard's tail, and it exhales fire, which the artist uses to melt and shape the glass.

The more I read about this condition, the more I read about my brother, an individual unlike anybody I have ever met before. Clearly, not only does my brother have Asperger's syndrome, he is the poster boy for it. A lack

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

4NG Fanatics

of interest in other people. Avoidance of eye-to-eye contact. A lack of social skills. Check, check, check.

It was a list. But when you combine the elements on the list, the result is a person most kindly described as "extremely eccentric."

A weight has been lifted. It's not all my fault. I'm not retarded. Or slow. It's him. It's always been him. And nobody knew it.

My next emotion is one of protection. I will now beat the *crap* out of anybody who is mean to my big, lumbering brother with his unusual, one-in-a-trillion brain.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Augusten Burroughs
Book: Magical Thinking: True Stories (pg 171-180)
ISBN: 978-0312315948
Publisher: Oct 2004
Date (Month/Year): St. Martin's Press

AWARD HISTORY

2005 National Qualifier

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY